

LOVE STORY

Amy and Dan's love story begins in a wild and unforgiving place, a few hundred miles that-a-way (*points into the distance*) in the North Sea.

Dan was stuck on a boat (as is often the case), halfway between Norway and Shetland. For those of you familiar with the shipping forecast, Dan was in an area known as Viking. Amy and Dan like to tell people they met in Viking because it sounds more exciting and more romantic than saying they met online.. which it does!

From his ship, Dan messaged a girl who looked really fun and adventurous.. AND her profile ended with what felt like the perfect p.s. for Dan: her profile ended with the line: 'it would help if you liked cycling.' "Wow" thought Dan - but he couldn't help thinking that maybe this lovely woman called Amy was a bit out of his league..

Amy was relieved to hear from someone who seemed to have so much in common with her. Dan looked like he loved travelling and adventure and he seemed to be a genuinely decent guy! Amy was also impressed with what appeared to be Antarctic exploration on his profile. So here was a kind and considerate man with an obvious love of nature and the outdoors. "Wow" thought Amy - and so their connection began, high above the wind and waves between Edinburgh and Viking.

Things got off to a great start, despite them being so far apart. Amy and Dan got to know each other by writing emails everyday.. for six weeks. Amy was impressed by the really long, friendly and funny emails Dan wrote every day without fail. She quickly began to realise what a lovely guy Dan was.

Dan's devotion to the challenge of writing to Amy everyday was quite something - and so lovely, now that Amy knows how long it actually takes Dan to write an email!

Amy must have known this was going places as she was writing a French book for schools at the time and included a reading text about a Scottish zoologist called Dan, who learned Russian to help with his work! Little did she know that they'd be celebrating the publication of the book a year later and Dan would be reading about himself!

Our couple started planning their first date for when Dan was home. They decided on Summerhall near the Meadows, at the lovely bar in the old vet school. Amy went for a pre-date, nerve-calming drink with Jenny - who seemed to know at the time that this could be something special - saying that she had a very good feeling about it all!

Dan consulted with his female friends about what to wear - as he thought Amy looked very glamorous - so he turned up wearing his smartest clothes and some very shiny shoes as he wanted to impress her!

The shoes obviously worked and the date was a bit of a success! Amy and Dan loved getting to know each other properly and after a few drinks and a lot of chatting, our couple had their first kiss in the meadows! (Who made the first move..?)

Amy and Dan started spending a lot of time together and found that they always had really good fun. Being together was so easy! They went on a weekend trip away to Lochearnhead, cycling and hiking. After a few days they were enjoying themselves so much that they decided to extend their mini-break, so they stayed an extra few nights at Mhor 84, where they are now going for the first night of their honeymoon on Monday.

Love and life became beautifully intertwined for Amy and Dan and our couple's relationship grew despite Dan's regular long trips away. They quickly learned how to make their time apart work as best as possible for them. There are always celebrations before Dan heads off-shore and they celebrate even more (of course!) when he comes back home.

Being apart makes Amy and Dan really appreciate all of the precious time they have together. Whether it's having loads of fun and going on exciting adventures, or hanging out at home; or going out for dinner and drinks, or simply cycling around Edinburgh, they simply enjoy being together.

There is a routine when Dan is away. Our chatty love-birds talk on the phone two or three times a day and they love making plans for the weeks when they are together again. Amy says it couldn't work so well without Dan being so reliable and considerate.

He always phones everyday. Dan really looks forward to hearing Amy's voice because she is always so chatty and happy. Amy makes Dan laugh and she understands his work so well that she could probably get a job on the project!

Amy loves planning and has planned many incredible holidays for them, often with an accompanying Powerpoint which she sends to Dan in the field! They've had amazing holidays in Amsterdam, skiing in France and their first road trip together took our intrepid duo to Iceland. They had an amazing holiday driving around the island, having lots of fun and adventures en route, including when they met Amy's friends Alison and Lissa. They spent the evening in a hot-tub made from a boat, with Dan being the barman!

They have also been lucky enough to visit some amazingly exotic places such as Namibia and Japan.. AND they had an amazing month-long trip to Argentina and Chile where they trekked in Patagonia, tangoed in Buenos Aires and partied in Valparaiso.

They moved in together in early 2015 and it was here that Amy and Dan discovered a shared creative and entrepreneurial streak. Their flat on Morningside Road became known as "HQ" because they would have AGM meetings where they would share ideas and dream up exciting projects.

Now most of us can dream up an idea.. but Amy and Dan actually turn their ideas into reality - and credit to them for that!

WILD ONES, Dan's wildlife education business, was born out of their inspiring chats. Dan works diligently on this brilliant educational project, building it up bit-by-bit when he's home and getting more and more bookings all the time.

As if that wasn't enough, our entrepreneurs also started 'POST ART' in Morningside - turning a stamp-collage gift (from Dan to Amy) into a full-scale, stamp-art habit and accompanying wee business : selling stamp-art collages, t-shirts, mugs, hoodies and tote bags.

A growing empire indeed! Dan has said he is happy to take orders or bookings after the ceremony!

On their amazing trip to Japan last year, (where Amy had been invited to speak at a conference), they managed to fit in a fantastic trip around Honshu where they ski-ed in Japan's famous powder snow. They visited Tokyo, Kyoto and Mount Fuji - and they experienced the temples, the snow monkeys and a fabulous Onsen (a natural hot spring). So many wonderful moments and on top of all that, there was of course the fantastic Japanese food and hospitality to enjoy! What an amazing high point their trip to Japan was - and it ended with our couple on cloud nine!

Amy and Dan felt so happy together in Japan and were chatting all the time about getting married, so it felt like a natural next step when Dan proposed to Amy during their last night out in Tokyo, on a rooftop bar above the famous Shi-bu-ya crossroads.

They made it official when they came home, buying the engagement ring and letting Willie and Christine and Libby and Pete know before sharing the news with family and friends. Everyone was over the moon and Amy and Dan would like to say how they have loved sharing the wedding-planning process with their families and friends.

It has been a really special time and Amy and Dan have loved planning their wedding together. It has made them feel closer and happier than ever before.

Amy and Dan bought their lovely house in Kirkliston Road together last year. This has made them both so happy and they love having friends and family to stay and spend time in their house and garden. The first day they moved in, they were able to pop open a bottle of champagne in the garden in the sun after a long day of moving boxes. Dan did a brilliant job of perfectly stacking all of the boxes like a giant game of Jenga!

Buying their own home together has been a huge step forward in their relationship. For Amy and Dan, having their own place together feels like a dream come true.

Amy and Dan, thank you for sharing your story with us SO FAR. Congratulations on everything you have achieved together in just a few short years.

You are inspirational people and together, you make an incredible team! We are all so proud and happy for you both on your wedding day!

Part of the appeal of a Humanist wedding ceremony is how personal it can be.

Today's celebration is exactly that - and this is what makes such a ceremony so special.

So we have heard their love-story so-far; however, Amy and Dan have written some words about each other and what their love story means - so it is my pleasure to share their words with you now.

I think we can call this part - 'What I love about you..'

Dan loves that Amy has so much good energy. She is an amazing person who has made him feel so happy in their first five years together. During this time (thanks to Amy's planning and encouragement), they have achieved so much together - including many well-planned trips to far flung destinations - in Scotland and further afield !

Amy is such an infectious, fun person to be around. In Dan's own words..

"She makes me smile and laugh from the start till the end of every day. She can literally make fun out of nothing!! Amy has the ability to pass on such a good, positive feeling to whoever she meets." Dan goes on to say:

"As well as being so much fun to spend time with, Amy is also the most caring and thoughtful person I have ever been fortunate to have met, and I can't believe I have been blessed to have her by my side as the love of my life.."

Amy loves that Dan is so kind, thoughtful, funny and generous. He is one of the most considerate people she has ever met! She loves how they share everything and that life is so easy and fun together. Dan is always up for everything. He doesn't mind Amy's constant planning, mind changing or occasional weepy moment!

Dan always looks after her!

Amy loves spending time with Dan, going cycling, walking, going to concerts, cooking, being daft and just chatting.

In Amy's words: "I feel that I'm at my most relaxed and happy when we're together. I feel so lucky to have met Dan. I am so happy to be with someone who loves me so unconditionally.

Dan makes life so full of fun and happiness, laughter and kindness."